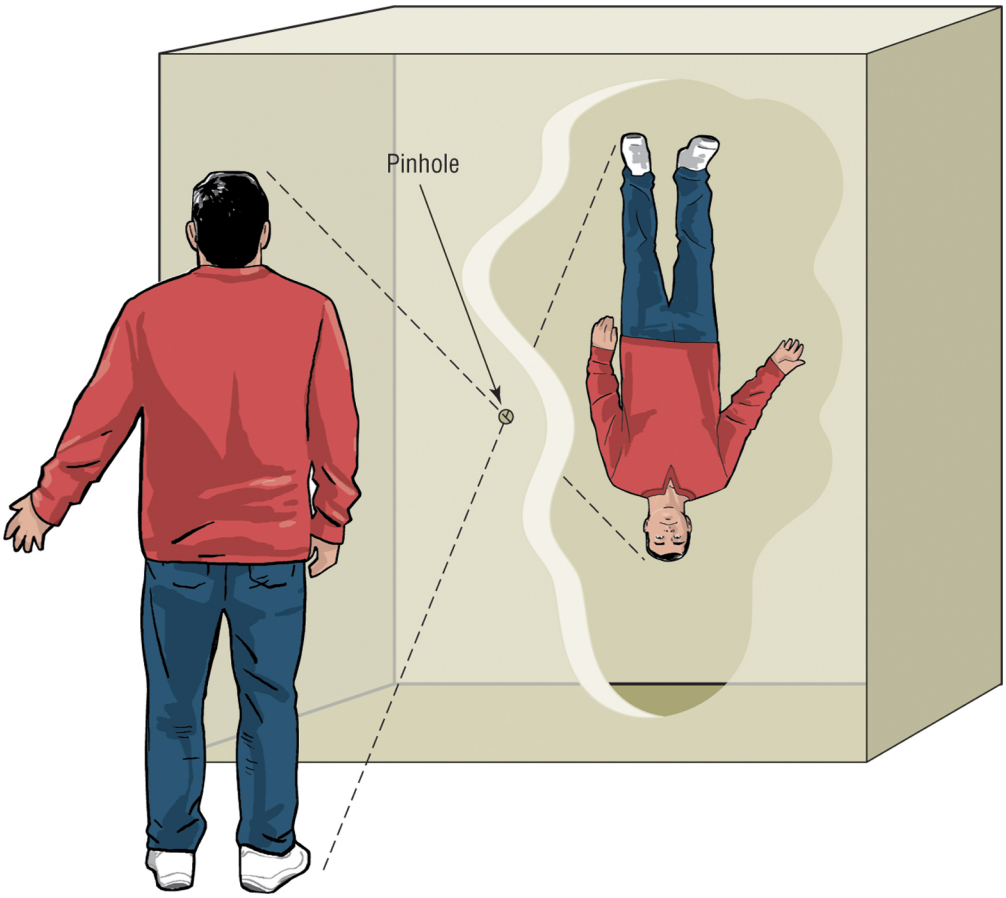
Film History

Precinema

Photography In one sense, movies are simply a natural progression in the history of photography. The word photography means, literally, “writing with light” and technically, “the static representation or reproduction of light.” The concept has its beginnings in ancient Greece. In the fourth century bce, the Greek philosopher Aristotle theorized about a device that later would be known as the camera obscura (Latin for “dark chamber”). In the late fifteenth century, Leonardo da Vinci’s drawings gave tangible form to the idea. Both simple and ingenious, the camera obscura may be a box or it may be a room large enough for a viewer to stand inside. Light entering through a tiny hole (later a lens) on one side of the box or room projects an image from the outside onto the opposite side or wall. An artist might then trace the image onto a piece of paper.

Before the advent of photosensitive film, the camera obscura was used to facilitate lifelike drawing. In this simple schematic, for example, the interior “wall” upon which the upside-down image is projected was usually whitened; an artist could place a piece of drawing paper on the wall and trace the image onto it.



Camera Obscura

Photography was developed during the first four decades of the nineteenth century by Thomas Wedgwood, William Henry Fox Talbot, and Sir John Herschel in England; Joseph-Nicéphore Niépce and Louis-Jacques-Mandé Daguerre in France; and George Eastman in the United States.

Series photography records the phases of an action. In a series of still photographs, we see, for example, a man or a horse in changing positions that suggest movement, though the images themselves are static. Within a few years, three men—Pierre-Jules-César Janssen, Eadweard Muybridge, and Étienne-Jules Marey—contributed to its development.

Eadweard Muybridge